

TV Analysis Exercise

Breaking Bad: Season 5, Episode 14 "Ozymandias"

(Desert Shootout (0:00 – 5:56)) <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=28kofqHQg6k>)

Breaking Bad's crucial episode, "Ozymandias," stands as a compelling portrayal of the interplay between hegemonic and counterhegemonic narratives within the crime drama genre. Particularly, the scene marking Hank Schrader's demise serves as a pivotal moment for unravelling power dynamics, entrenched cultural meanings, and narrative construction. This critical juncture not only highlights shifting power dynamics but also employs meticulous visual symbolism and thematic ties to Percy Bysshe Shelley's poem "Ozymandias," resonating with broader discussions on discourses and power relations, echoing the post-structuralist insights of Michel Foucault. The visual portrayal in this sequence encompasses the stark desert landscape, characters' body language, and the poignant event of Hank's death. However, it is the implicit associations within these visuals that resonate profoundly. The barren desert mirrors the moral vacuum within which Walter White operates, symbolizing the irreversible consequences of his choices. Hank's stoic demeanour, a blend of bravery and resignation, embodies a tragic hero facing an inevitable demise, invoking themes of sacrifice and the transient nature of power. Walter's subsequent collapse after Hank's death metaphorically mirrors the downfall of an empire, reinforcing thematic ties to Shelley's poem and emphasizing the ephemeral nature of power.

Intertextuality is employed to enhance narrative impact. The alignment between the episode's title, teaser trailer featuring Bryan Cranston's recitation of "Ozymandias," and subsequent events acts as a prelude to the impending downfall, encapsulating the unfolding tragic events. Walter's futile plea to spare Hank, offering his entire fortune, further accentuates the moral decay and misguided hope in a system impaired by power and corruption. Within this hegemonic narrative, counterhegemonic elements emerge through Hank's unwavering adherence to principles, challenging the notion that power demands moral compromise. Hank's reproach of Walter's misguided beliefs disrupts simplistic portrayals of power dynamics prevalent in hegemonic narratives. The episode showcases Breaking Bad's dramatic intensity, delving into themes of moral decay and unchecked ambition. Further analysis through Fairclough's critical discourse analysis reveals intersecting dominant ideologies with the mythologies of the American Dream and individualism. Walter's transformation challenges the idealized pursuit of success, unmasking societal moral decay. These challenge hegemonic norms of success and power, resonating with Gerbner and Gross's observations on television violence and unveiling deeper societal issues ingrained within media narratives.

Ultimately, this episode's profound exploration of power, morality, and human frailty transcends the confines of conventional narratives. The intricate layers of meaning and cultural critique within this scene exemplify the show's prowess in qualitative textual analysis, prompting audiences to contemplate the multifaceted nature of societal constructs and individual agency in contemporary television storytelling.